

fridayReview

THE HINDU

Best foot forward

The Music Academy’s Mid-Year Dance Festival showcased promising young talents **p2**

Inspired by Ustad Ali Akbar Khan

The annual Swara Samrat Festival brought together rising stars from different gharanas **p3**



BEYOND THE NORTHEAST LABEL

Filmmakers from the region continue to grapple with stereotyping **p4**

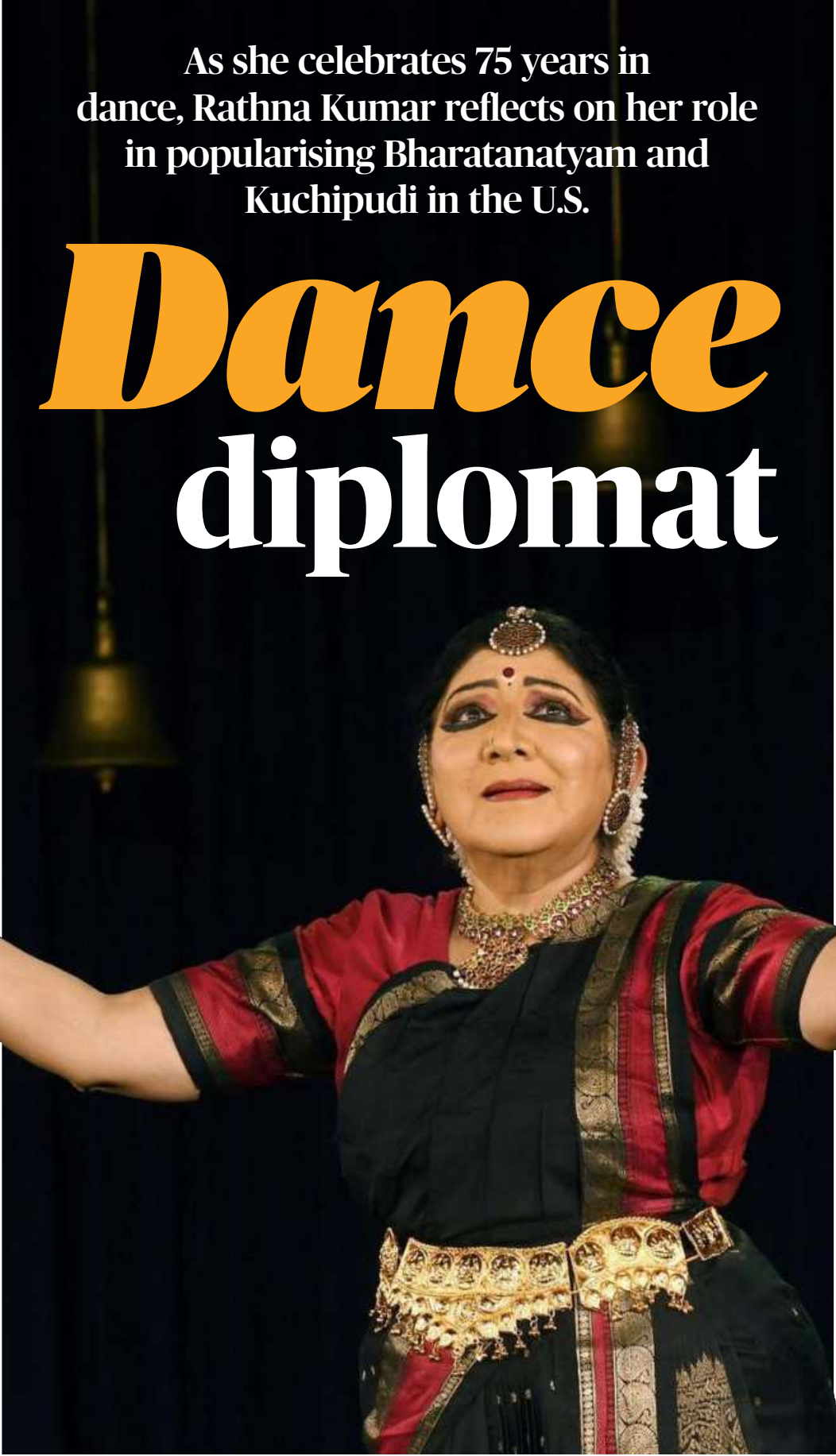
Art away from home A young Rathna Kumar (below); performing at Chennai’s Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan for Pravasi Utsavam in 2019. PHOTOS: THE HINDU ARCHIVES & R. RAVINDRAN



N.C. Srinivasaraghavan

Known affectionately as ‘Rathna Papa’ when she first stepped into the dance classroom as a child, Rathna Kumar completes 75 years in dance this year. Yet, after a lifetime devoted to Bharatanatyam and Kuchipudi, she rejects the idea of artistic finality. “You never master dance,” she says. “You remain a student all your life.” Bharatanatyam formed the foundation of her training under K.J. Sarasa, who accepted her as her very first student, while her transition to Kuchipudi began under Vempati Pedda Satyam before she came under the tutelage of Vempati Chinna Satyam, with whom she continued her training, rebuilding her technique from the ground up. Studies in Kathak, Mohiniyattam and Odissi further enriched her understanding of movement, and an early encounter with the legendary Ram Gopal, who urged her to devote herself entirely to Kuchipudi, foreshadowed the path her career would eventually take. Looking back, she believes dancers should first establish a firm grounding in one tradition before embracing another. Reflecting on the evolution of Kuchipudi, Rathna feels that the form has gradually lost much of the grace and fluidity

that defined the style taught by her guru, Vempati Chinna Satyam. Lamenting that performances today often prioritise speed, sharp lines and athletic precision over seamless movement, she credits her guru with refining the tradition for the female body without altering its essential vocabulary, insisting on elegance and restraint. For Rathna, preserving Kuchipudi’s distinctive identity is more important than adapting to changing aesthetic trends. Teaching was never part of Rathna’s original plan. After moving to Houston in the U.S. in 1975 following her marriage, she enrolled in a PhD programme in English at Rice University in Texas. Unsure whether she possessed the knowledge to teach, she frequently sought reassurance from her gurus. Vempati Chinna Satyam’s words became her guiding philosophy: “The Upanishads tell us that when we die, we can take neither our *vidya* (education) nor our *dhanam* (wealth) with us. Therefore, during your lifetime you must distribute both.” K.J. Sarasa’s counsel was equally influential. Teaching, Rathna discovered, did not diminish her artistry but deepened it. “In the process of becoming a



As she celebrates 75 years in dance, Rathna Kumar reflects on her role in popularising Bharatanatyam and Kuchipudi in the U.S.

Dance diplomat

teacher, I was becoming a better dancer.” Nearly five decades later, that journey has grown into a legacy. At the heart of it is the Anjali Center for Performing Arts, where students who first learnt from her in the 1970s now return with their children, while some others rediscover dance after long breaks taken for careers and family. For Kumar, these intergenerational relationships embody the true spirit of the guru-sishya tradition. “Dance will not end with my generation,” she says.

“There is continuity. There is hope.” Her influence extends well beyond the Indian diaspora. After early masterclasses across American universities, Rathna found a permanent home at Rice University, where she has taught since 2002. Most of her students are not of Indian origin, yet her classes remain oversubscribed. She deliberately teaches Bharatanatyam and Kuchipudi as liberal arts disciplines rather than collections of steps, introducing students to history, literature, philosophy,

storytelling and the language of *mudras*. Many leave with a deeper appreciation of Indian civilisation, and some have even travelled to India after discovering its performing arts through her classroom. The same desire to build cultural understanding inspired the founding of ‘Samskriti’ more than three decades ago. Through the Houston-based non-profit, Rathna has presented leading Indian artists while also creating ambitious cross-cultural productions. One such was her *Ramayana*,

Marking a milestone

Seetha Ratnakar and Bharat Kalachar present ‘Navaratna’ – Rathna Kumar’s seven-decade journey – on July 25 (6 p.m.) at Bharat Kalachar. The event will include ‘Sarasa Natana Mala’ by the senior students of Sarasalaya, ‘Ratna Mala’ by dancer and raconteuse Ramaa Bharadwaj and felicitations by renowned artistes and industrialist Nalli Kuppuswami Chetti.

which brought together Bharatanatyam, Thai, Indonesian, Sri Lankan and Kathak traditions alongside Gamelan and Indian music. It demonstrated that artistic collaboration need not compromise classical integrity. Rathna is equally forthright about the challenges facing Indian classical dance today. She laments the growing pay-to-perform culture, where young dancers often bear the cost of venues, orchestra and production simply to gain visibility. She advocates stronger institutional funding, government grants and opportunities for emerging artistes, suggesting that senior performers should regularly include young dancers as opening acts. At Samskriti, every performer – from internationally acclaimed artistes to children in small roles – receives an honorarium because, she believes, organisations must practise the values they espouse. Her choreography similarly reflects a conviction that classical dance must engage with the present while remaining rooted in tradition. Productions such as *Ahimsa*, *Purnam* and *A Story, A Song and A Dance* explore terrorism, disability, grief and healing through the classical vocabulary. The belief became deeply personal after she lost her son during the COVID-19

pandemic. Returning to dance through online classes helped her emerge from profound grief. “People often speak about the healing power of the arts,” she reflects. “After COVID, I experienced it personally.” For Rathna Kumar, dance is not merely performance – it is education, cultural dialogue, social reflection and, ultimately, a source of hope. Reflecting on the future of Bharatanatyam and Kuchipudi, Rathna believes that today’s dancers are often under pressure to achieve too much, too quickly. “Don’t be in a hurry,” she advises. “Dance matures slowly.” Technique alone, however, is never enough. She urges young dancers to cultivate the mind as much as the body. Literature, poetry, history, theatre, painting, architecture, travel and music all enrich a dancer’s imagination. “Dance is about life. If you don’t understand life, what exactly are you expressing?” she asks. Perfectly executed movements, she believes, remain empty unless they are informed by thought, curiosity and lived experience. The greatest artistes are those whose interests extend well beyond the boundaries of their own discipline. These convictions have shaped not only her teaching but also her work as a choreographer and arts administrator. Through initiatives such as *Let’s Create*, she has encouraged emerging choreographers by offering grants that enable them to transform ideas into productions. Rather than prescribing themes, she urges them to discover their own artistic voices. The resulting works have ranged from mythology and history to contemporary personalities like Malala Yousafzai, reaffirming her belief that classical dance possesses the power to engage with the concerns of every generation. As the conversation ends, she recalls a quotation by American choreographer Agnes de Mille that appears at the end of every email she sends: “*Everything passes. Art alone, enduring, stays to us.*” Those words reflect her own journey. Performances conclude, careers evolve, and honours fade, but art continues to inspire and transform lives. It is this enduring faith in dance that has sustained Rathna Kumar through 75 remarkable years. If she is remembered, she hopes it will simply be as someone who loved the art wholeheartedly.

Mali - 100

The Museum of Performing Arts Foundation (MOPA) will present ‘The Wind Walker’ – a centennial exhibition on the life and music of flute maestro T.R. Mahalingam (Mali). It will be held from July 30 to August 2 (11 a.m. to 8 p.m.) at My Bungalow, Eldams Road. The inaugural day will feature a talk by T.M. Krishna, followed by a concert by Mala Chandrashekar. The concluding day will feature a concert by J.A. Jayant. The exhibition will showcase rare hand-written documents, including Mali’s letters to disciple T.S. Sankaran, an autobiographical note, a recorded talk by historian V. Sriram, photographs and recordings – offering an intimate portrait of Mali the artiste and visionary. Established in 2017, MOPA aims to spotlight South India’s rich artistic heritage through exhibitions, documentaries, lectures and concerts.

CULTUREBRIEFS



Dedicated to a guru

Natya Manjari presents ‘Shathavaarshikotsava’ – a centenary celebration of Guru Udupi Laxminarayan on July 26, 4 p.m. at Narada Gana Sabha. The event will be presided by film director S.P. Muthuraman, Narthaki Nataraj, Chitra Visweswaran, V.V. Sundaram and Nandakumar (IRS). On the occasion, Natyacharya V.P. Dhananjayan and Muger Sundar will be honoured with the Lifetime Achievement Award (Kalaa Praveen). The Narthaka Praveena will be given to Bala Gurunath, Binesh Mahadevan, K.B. Madhusudhanan, K. Gopinathan, Narendran Kumar, Shanmuga Sundaram, Shivakumar and Parshwanath Upadhiye. The evening also includes performances by Natya Manjari students, Prabhu Deva and Nagendra Prasad and grandchildran of the guru and daughter Udupi Madhumathy Prakash. Guru Udupi Laxminarayan (1926–2015), an exponent of the Kanchipuram style and a disciple of Guru Kanchipuram Ellappa Mudaliar, founded Natya Manjari in Chennai in 1962. He trained several students with emphasis on technique, expression and tradition. He developed a systematic approach to teaching adavus, making Bharatanatyam structured and accessible. His choreographic works are notable for their artistic excellence.



Musical ode

Kalyani Menon Foundation presents a Carnatic vocal recital by Vignesh Ishwar, accompanied by R.K. Shriramkumar on the violin, Praveen Sparsh on the mridangam and Anirudh Athreya on the kanjira. The concert will be at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall, The Music Academy, on August 2, 10.30 a.m.

Kalki award

The annual Kalki Krishnamurthy memorial award will be presented to vocalist Vignesh Ishwar on August 1. Senior musician Bombay Jayashri will preside and present the award, which will be followed by Vignesh’s concert at 6 p.m. Venue: Ragasudha Hall. The Kalki Krishnamurthy Memorial Award is given every year to young Carnatic musicians.



The Music Academy Mid-Year Dance Festival is dedicated to nurturing emerging talent

Moods and movements

V.V. Ramani

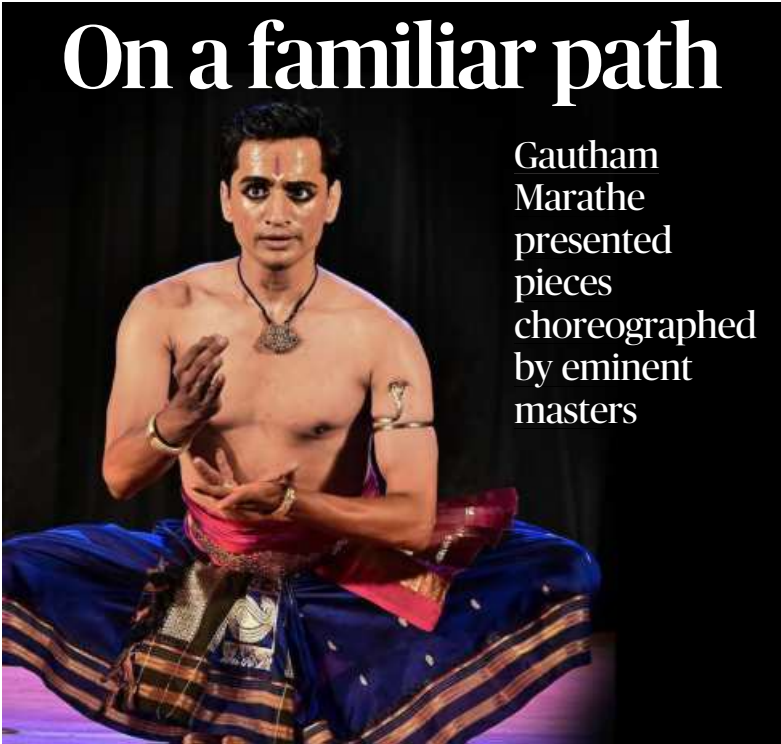
The Music Academy Mid-Year Dance Festival began on an exuberant note with Shahana Kasi's performance. The festival platforms young and promising artists. Shahana, a disciple of Parvathi Ravi Ghantasala, was backed by a strong musical ensemble, which kept up the momentum throughout. Shahana began with a kirtanam 'Dasha shata dala', composed by G.N. Balasubramaniam in raga Hamsanadham, invoking the goddess of learning. Using simple

sancharis, she highlighted the different attributes of goddess Saraswathi. The centrepiece of the recital was the popular Thodi padavarnam 'Daanike thagujanara', composed by Sivanandam (Thanjavur Quartet). The song, describes how the heroine expresses her love for the king through her sakhi, who in turn describes the beauty of the nayika and convinces the king that she will be a perfect match for him. The clarity in depicting each character made the piece appealing. Nritha segments were brief but Shahana's footwork and movements added sparkle.

The melodious strains of raga Behag by the violinist, set the mood for the introduction of Kuchela in the Swati Tirunal padam 'Smaratinumam sadayam'. In the episode, where Kuchela goes to meet his childhood friend Krishna, Shahana's evocative portrayal captured the varied shades of emotions. A lively thillana in Bindumalini raga, composed by flute maestro N. Ramani, made for a fine finale. The musical ensemble was an asset to the performance with Raghuram V. Rajagopalan's bhava-rich singing, Kiran R. Pai perfect strokes on the mridangam, B. Ananthakrishnan on the violin and E. Devraj on the flute.

V.V. Ramani

Tisra nadai alarippu, presented with finesse, evoked a sense of serenity in Gautham Marathe's performance at The Music Academy's Mid-Year Dance Festival. Choreographed by the legendary guru C. V. Chandrasekhar, the piece came alive through vibrant footwork patterns and crisp adavu execution. Matching the sparkle of Kalishwaran's sollukattus, the dancer maintained an assured rhythmic command, making the segment particularly engaging. The Sankarabharanam varnam, 'Manavi Chekona', composed by Ponniah Pillai of the Thanjavur Quartet, centred on a lovelorn nayika's fervent appeal to Lord Brihadeeswara to ease the anguish of separation. Gautam vividly



Gautham Marathe presented pieces choreographed by eminent masters

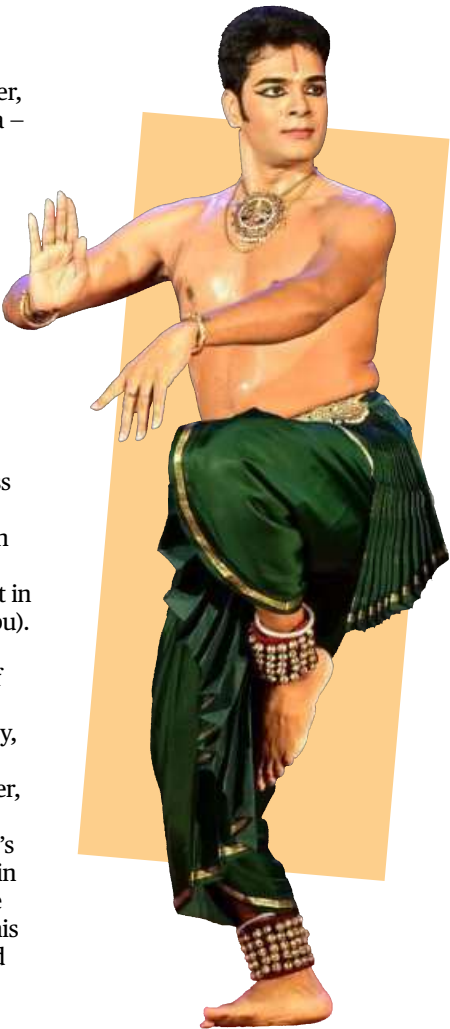
PHOTOS: K. PICHUMANI

Making it his own

While staying rooted in his guru's choreography, Mithun Shyam lent a distinct touch to timeless compositions

Manasa Vijaylakshme C

Mithun Shyam, disciple of Padmini Ramachandran, presented an engaging Bharatanatyam recital at the Music Academy's Mid-Year Dance Festival. He began with Thodayamangalam in ragas Kedara and Hussemi, setting the tone for the evening. This was followed by alarippu in Sankarabharanam, set to Rupaka tala. The centrepiece of the recital was Veenai Sessa Iyer's varnam 'Devadhi deva', choreographed by his guru, and set in raga Shanmukhapriya, Adi tala. Preceded by a virutham in raga Revathi, the piece invoked Nataraja of Chidambaram through the Bhikshatanar episode from the Darukavana legend. Mithun vividly portrayed Shiva's manifestation as the radiant mendicant who humbles the ritualistic sages, whose fury culminates in the release of a tiger, serpent, deer, fire and Apasmara – all of which Shiva effortlessly subdues and transforms into symbols of his cosmic dance. Interwoven with these episodes was the devotee's heartfelt plea for the Lord's grace, the removal of past karmas and reassurance amidst moments of longing and doubt. While remaining faithful to his guru's choreography, Mithun lent a distinct touch to the sancharis, bringing freshness to the timeless composition. He next presented the seventh Ashtapadi 'Maamiyam chalitha', from Jayadeva's *Gita Govinda*, set in raga Sindhubhairavi (Misra Chapu). The composition explores a rare and deeply introspective facet of Krishna. Departing from the familiar image of the playful deity, Krishna is portrayed in this composition as a remorseful lover, tormented by the memory of having failed to recognise Radha's anguish and watching her leave in hurt. As he wanders through the forest in despair, he reflects on his folly, yearning for her return and realising that life without her is bereft of meaning. Through



portrayed her journey of devotion – from entering the sanctum sanctorum and performing the rituals of worship to adorning the deity and finally surrendering at the Lord's feet. Raghuram Rajagopalan's soulful singing enhanced the presentation. The idea that the divine household in Kailasa is no different from the joys and challenges of earthly family life formed the core of 'Subhashitam', an abhinaya piece choreographed by the legendary Kanak Rele. Revolving around the sibling rivalry between Ganesha and Karthikeya, and Parvati's role as a mediator between her sons, the piece offered an engaging narrative. However, the brevity of the presentation left little scope to explore the nuances well. Gautam next took up Arunachala Kavirayar's famous Bhairavi composition 'Yaaro ivar yaaro', which describes the moment when Rama, accompanying Vishwamitra and Lakshmana to Mithila, sees Sita for the first time. Enchanted by the girl standing on a balcony, he is overcome with wonder and curiosity, giving rise to a series of questions about her identity. The visualisation of these two pieces lacked spontaneity and seemed rehearsed, with even Rama's surprise at his first glimpse of Sita looking premeditated rather than instinctive. A deeper and more nuanced exploration could have enhanced the appeal. The recital regained its momentum with the lively Hindolam thillana, bringing the performance to a close. Harsha Samaga Malpe on the mridangam and Viswesh Swaminathan on the violin provided able musical support throughout.

CULTURE-BRIEFS

Vocal concert

Hamsadhwani presents Supriya Raja's vocal concert, organised as part of its 'Kalaigalil Ilaya Bharatham' series, on July 26, 6.15 p.m. at Youth Hostel, Adyar. Supriya will be accompanied by S. Haritha Narayanan on the violin and Jayendra on the mridangam.



Tirtha jayanti offering

Narada Gana Sabha, in association with the Thirupoonthuruthi Narayana Thirtha Swamigal Trust, has organised the following concerts as part of the 351st Narayana Tirtha jayanthi celebrations. To be held tomorrow, the event will begin at 4.15 p.m. with a vocal performance by Padmini Ravi and her disciples Amruthavarshini, Bhargavi and Rangayanaki. The ensemble will also include R. Naveen (violin) and Madurai T. Karthik (mridangam). This will be followed by Archana and Samanvi's vocal concert (5.50 p.m.) with Sreelakshmi S. Bhat (violin), Aduthurai G. Guruprasad (mridangam) and P. Giridara Prasad (kanjira). Venue: Swami Haridhos Giri hall.



Celebrating a legacy

Chennai Fine Arts, in association with the Ganakalanidhi Vinjamuri Dr. Varadaraja Iyengar Memorial Trust, commemorates the 111th birth anniversary of the Carnatic musician, composer, musicologist and researcher with a thematic programme 'Vaggeyakara Vaibhavam' on July 25, 6 p.m. at Srinivasa Sastri Hall, Mylapore. The evening will feature Maharajapuram S. Ramachandran's vocal concert with V.V. Srinivasa Rao on the violin, J. Vaidyanathan on the mridangam and B.S. Purushotham on the kanjira.

Vocal and veena

Madhuradhwani will host the following programmes at Arkay Convention Centre, Mylapore. Details: Today, 6.15 p.m.: Delhi V. Muthukumar (vocal). July 25, 6.30 p.m.: Nirmala Rajasekar (veena). July 26, 6.15 p.m.: Udayalur Kalyanaraman's namasankirtanam.

Well-curated Iyer sisters with B. Ganapathyraman on the mridangam and Hariharasubramaniyan on the ghatam. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

exchange of notes between the sisters. The tani avartanam between Ganapathyraman and Hariharasubramaniyan was crisp with catchy rhythmic patterns. The post-tani session included a popular Sankarabharanam English note, 'Baro krishnayya' in ragamalika, a Tiruppugazh in Sindhubhairavi and a thillana by M. Balamuralikrishna in Kathanakuthuhalam. One wished the sisters had explored the ragas, especially Pantuvarali, in greater depth, though today's rasikas often prefer more variety in a concert.

Strings in sync

R.S. Sudha and R.S. Srividhya's concert repertoire featured popular kritis and a variety of ragas

G. Swaminathan

Paalam TV regularly curates themed concert series, offering a digital platform for artistes and interesting musical content for rasikas. Violinotsav was a week-long festival dedicated to the violin, featuring mostly duo

performances and one trio. The concert by Iyer Sisters – R.S. Sudha and R.S. Srividhya – consisted of a wide variety of ragas and popular kritis. The duo was supported by B. Ganapathyraman on the mridangam and Hariharasubramaniyan on the ghatam. There was never a dull



moment with expansive raga essays and swaraprastaras. Pallavi Gopala Iyer's 'Entho prema' Surutti varnam set the tone of the concert. A short sketch of Pantuvarali by Srividhya led to Tyagaraja's 'Ninne nera nammi.' This was followed by 'Thaye

tripurasundari' in Suddha Saveri (Periasami Thooran) with chittaswara and swarakalpana. Before Srividhya ventured into the Saveri alapana, Tyagaraja's 'Entha muddho' in raga Bindumalini was played. Saveri raga treatise was

melodic, and the selection here was Syama Sastri's 'Sankari Samkuru'. Swati Tirunal's 'Boogendra sayeenam' in Kuntalavarali preceded a detailed raga alapana of Hemavathi by Sudha, who brought out the myriad shades through her

slow and steady development of the alapana. Muthuswami Dikshitar's 'Sri kantimatim' was the chosen kriti with niraval and swarakalpana on 'Sukha sounakaadi sadaradhitam.' Shadjam-oriented swaras dominated the seamless

Swara Samrat Festival's Delhi edition featured vocalists and instrumentalists who offered engaging interpretations of diverse gharana styles.



Young masters
(Clockwise from left)
Sarodist Indrayudh Majumder of the Maihar gharana; Pt. Nayan Ghosh's son Ishaan Ghosh; and vocalist Armaan Khan. PHOTOS: COURTESY: SWARA SAMRAT FESTIVAL

Sound of a new generation

Shailaja Khanna
Swara Samrat Festival, which began 14 years ago in Kolkata in memory of Ustad Ali Akbar Khan, has expanded to other cities over the past three years. The second Delhi edition of the festival, held recently, featured only young musicians.
The festival opened with a dhrupad vocal recital by Bangladesh-born Niloy Ahsan, who is currently training under Ustad Wasifuddin Dagar. Earlier, he studied with the Gundecha Brothers. Niloy possesses a powerful voice, and the range he displayed, extending into the mandra saptak, was particularly impressive. He presented Mian ki Malhar, beginning with an expansive 45-minute alap that left him with barely 10 minutes for the compositions that followed. He was accompanied on the pakhawaj by the talented Roman Das.
This imbalance in time management was unfortunate, as

Niloy displayed a string sense of drama in his layakari – which was all too brief. The well-known Chautaal composition 'Aayi ghata' was not sung in full, perhaps owing to the lack of time. The overdrawn alap in the vilambit section also saw Niloy expanding the notes, presenting shrutis to the point of dissonance, which was unaesthetic. Another avoidable distraction was his use of a head mic, uncommon among classical vocalists. It does not allow for volume control and picks up every breath while singing in detail. Niloy had a cold and blowing his nose a couple of times with the mic picking up every sound was not pleasant.
Next performance was by Mumbai-based Farrukhabad gharana tabla artiste Ishaan Ghosh. Son of Pt. Nayan Ghosh, Ishaan has been performing since his early teens; despite being only 26, he displays remarkable polish and maturity on stage. His command over the tabla baaj, sense of proportion in presentation and tremendous dexterity on the

instrument are exemplary. Accompanied by Delhi-based sarangi player Mudassir Khan, Ishaan performed in teentaal. Gradually building momentum, he presented an impressive array of compositions drawn from the Delhi, Ajrada, Lucknow, Banaras, and, of course, Farrukhabad traditions.
When Ishaan played a composition by Mian Bakshu, founder of the Lucknow gharana of tabla, it underscored the importance of provenance in sustaining the continuity of the Indian classical tradition. While the tabla tradition carefully preserves the lineage of compositions, their origins are often forgotten in vocal and instrumental music. Ishaan made an interesting point: each composition has its own *tehzeeb* of presentation, and playing every composition at an extremely fast pace to display virtuosity is not right.
The concluding artiste of the day was sitarist Mehtab Ali Niazi, accompanied by his brother



Khurram on the tabla. Mumbai-based Mehtab, who hails from the vocal Bhendi Bazaar gharana, draws inspiration from Ustad Vilayat Khan's sitar style. He too played Mian ki Malhar. A polished performer with evident *riyaz*, Mehtab is perhaps yet to attain complete command over raga exposition. His treatment of

Malhar in the alap and jor leaned more on phrases than on a seamless unfolding of the raag. However, it is admirable how he lends novelty to his concerts; this time, he played jhala in different beats rather than the usual four-beat 'seedha' and 'ulta' jhala. All his compositions were set to Jhaptal, including an appealing tarana. Khurram was outstanding in the *drut* section, at times drawing attention away from his brother.
The second day commenced with a flute recital by the 25-year-old Bengaluru-based Shadaj Godkhindi, who belongs to the Kirana gharana. He was accompanied by Ajirara gharana tabla player, Zargham. Shadaj presented raag Bhimpalasi, in the 'tantrakaari' style of 'alap jor jhala', followed by a composition in Rupak, then Teentaal. Shadaj's breath control, melodious meends and layakari were admirable; Zargham aligned with the mood well.
Kolkata-based sarodist Indrayudh Majumdar from the Maihar gharana, commenced his concert with raag Bihag; a carefully studied presentation where each movement appeared thought out. His jor was impressive. On the tabla was Mumbai-based Ojas Adhiya who brought his usual inimitable

energy to the concert. One must laud the organisers for presenting talented accompanists. Indrayudh concluded with a melodious Des. He presented a 'gat' attributed wrongly to Ustad Allaadin Khan (actually it predates him, and is an old Senia composition), then played a similar composition composed by Ustad Bahadur Khan. Indrayudh's concert was rich in content and also imaginative.
The festival came to close with a vocal recital by Armaan Khan of the Rampur Sahaswan gharana. Son of the legendary Rashid Khan, Armaan's stage presence and confidence are infectious. His *khuli awaaz* commands instant attention. His affability with his co-artists – Shubh Maharaj on the tabla, Lalit Sisodiya on the harmonium and Rick Mukherjee on the flute – brought out the best in them. Presenting raag Bageshwari, Armaan established the raag in a leisurely manner for around 30 minutes before concluding with the popular 'Kaa karun sajni'.
The festival brought together some of the finest young artistes on a platform backed by excellent sound and lighting. Equally laudable was the effort to ensure the presence of senior musicians in the audience to encourage these youngsters.



CALENDAR

Exploring karanas

U.S.-based Bharatanatyam dancer Bala Devi Chandrashekar presents a lecture demonstration 'Rasa – The Aesthetic Experience in Bharatanatyam and Indian Temple Sculpture' and a performance, today, 6.30 p.m. at NCPA's Little Theatre. The presentation, based on her production 'Mauli – A Timeless Tradition', explores the karanas, as represented in South Indian temples, particularly the Thanjavur temple tradition. Through dance, music and visual interpretation, it highlights how bhava transforms into rasa, creating profound aesthetic and spiritual experiences.

Interactive session

The Kural Trust celebrates its third anniversary on July 26, 10 a.m., at Ragasudha Hall, Mylapore. Musician-composer Rajkumar Bharathi is the chief guest. The event includes an interactive Carnatic jam featuring Rangappriya and Pazhani Balaji at 11 a.m.



Play time

Chromepet Cultural Academy presents PMG Mayurapriya's Tamil play *Ennadi Penne* on July 25, 6.15 p.m. at its auditorium.
Bharat Kalachar in association with Roshini Fine Arts and Abbas will stage two plays at the Bengal Association Hall on July 26: UAA's *Varadu Kutty - Paritchaikku Neramachu* - 2 at 4.30 p.m. and Crazy Balaji's *Madhil Mel Madhu* at 7 p.m.



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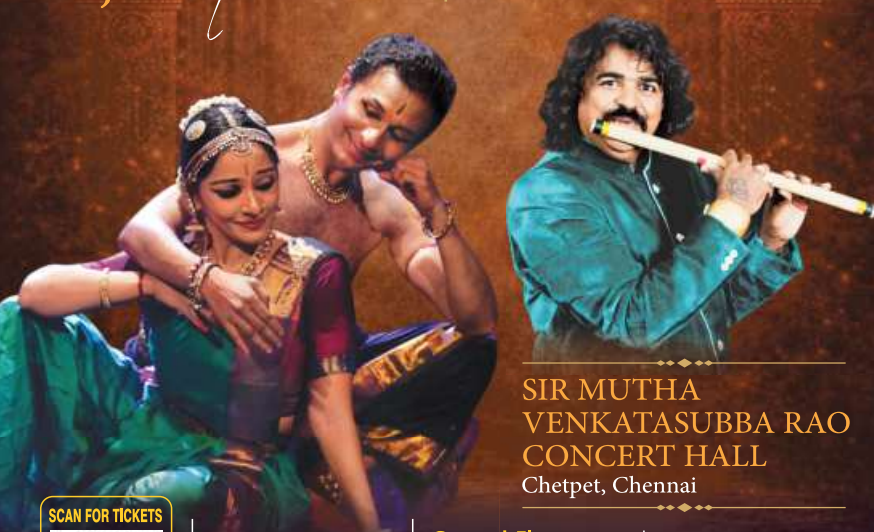
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Parthajit Baruah

Cinema from the Northeast has been quietly making waves on the global stage since the 1980s. Yet, its journey, which began in 1935, has often unfolded in the shadows – overlooked, marginalised and debated. With its eight states – Assam, Manipur, Arunachal Pradesh, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, Tripura and Sikkim – Northeast continues to be one of India’s most stereotyped regions: labelled as a conflict zone, prone to insurgency, it is often viewed as an exotic, monolithic entity.

The works of many filmmakers from the region have drawn global attention and been screened at international film festivals. This is not a recent phenomenon; cinema from the Northeast has attracted attention even in the past. For instance, in 1981, Aribam Syam Sharma’s feature film *Imagi Ningthem* (My Son, My Precious) won Montgolfiere d’Or at the Festival of Three Continents in Nantes. His 1990 film *Ishanou* (The Chosen One) was screened at the Un Certain Regard section at the 1991 Cannes Film Festival. Veteran filmmaker Aribam says, “I did not like it when *Ishanou* was called a ‘Manipuri or a Northeastern film’ by a journalist from Chennai. They should have known that the film was the only Indian entry at the Cannes Festival in 1991.”

Twelve-time National award-winning filmmaker Jahn timer Barua’s *Halodhia Chorai Baodhan Khai* (The Catastrophe, 1987) portrays the exploitation of destitute farmers. It won the Silver Leopard and the Prize of the Ecumenical Jury – Special Mention at the Locarno International Film Festival in 1988. Barua too faced a similar situation. “I was in Udaipur to attend a film festival as a guest and was mistaken for a foreigner at a five-star hotel I had to stay in. I informed the front desk that I was from Assam, but they insisted on seeing my passport. Eventually, the manager arrived and resolved the issue,” he shares. Despite such challenges, these filmmakers made a global mark with



Stories without labels

Their films may be rooted in the Northeast realities, but the directors reject being defined by geography alone

their powerful stories and paved the way for the next generation. The second generation filmmakers focus more on local stories with a universal appeal. Filmmaker Rima Das made history when her film *Village Rockstars* (2017) was selected as India’s official entry for the 90th Academy Awards in the Best Foreign Language Film category. The story follows Dhunu, a poor 10-year-old girl who dreams of having a rock-band. Pradip Kurbah’s *Lewduh* (Market, 2019) had its premiere at the 24th Busan International Film Festival.

Set in Shillong’s Bara Bazar, the film depicts the lives of the common man with stories that remain unnoticed. Pradip won the Kim Jiseok Award and became the first Indian to win it. His film, *The Elysian Field* (2025), is set in the Khasi Hills in 2047, where only six villagers live after most have migrated to the city. The film explores friendship and resilience of this community as their village slowly disappears. It won awards at the 47th Moscow International Film Festival. Says Pradip, “I cannot deny the existence of the ‘Northeast label’ in

India. I am delighted to represent my region. My films have a universal element that anybody in the world can relate to.” Dominic Sangma, who, like Pradip, is from Meghalaya, explores a complex narrative in his Garo feature film, *Rimdogittanga* (Rapture, 2023), which follows a 10-year-old boy with night blindness as he faces adversaries within a village plagued by child abductors. The film was selected for the Locarno Film Festival. Manipur’s Haobam Paban Kumar’s debut feature film *Loktak Lairembee* (Lady of the Lake, 2017) had its world premiere at the Busan International Film Festival and won the German Star of India at the 14th Indian Film Festival in Stuttgart in 2017.

The emergence of young filmmakers has expanded the possibilities of Northeast cinema. Among them, Tribeny Rai from Sikkim, an SRFTI graduate, stands out. Her debut feature film, *Shape of Momo* (2025), offers an intimate portrait of Bishnu, a young woman who returns to her village from Delhi and confronts persistent patriarchal norms. The film addresses gender, migration, family obligation and resistance. It premiered at the Busan International Film Festival and won two awards. “I believe issues of

Impact makers (left) A still from Rima Das’ acclaimed film *Village Rockstars*; and 12-time National Award-winning filmmaker Jahn timer Barua. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



identity and discrimination are important and everyone faces some form of discrimination, irrespective of who or where we are from. When I attend film festivals or participate in workshops outside India, people never ask me whether I am from Sikkim or Manipur; they simply recognise me as an Indian filmmaker. So, the issue exists within India, not abroad,” she says. Similarly, Maharshi Tuhi Kashyap from Assam, also an SRFTI graduate, came into the spotlight with his debut film – *Kok Kok Kokoook* (2025). Set in contemporary Guwahati, the story revolves around

a migrant chicken vendor whose attachment to his red RX100 motorcycle becomes central to his identity and belonging. The film, premiered in the Vision section at the Busan International Film Festival, reflects Maharshi’s engagement with the changing cultural and political landscape of Assam. Khanjan Kishore Nath’s Karbi-language film, *Kangbo Aloti* (The Lost Path, 2025), which has also done the festival circuit, takes up a contemporary issue of Karbi Anglong in Assam. The story follows Longsing, a member of a local militant group, assigned to recruit new members. His perspective changes after meeting a school teacher and the villagers. Many others from the region such as Sange Dorjee Thongdok, Romi Meitei, Kivini Shohe, Tiakumzuk Aier, Prashant Rasaily, Dawa Lepcha, Mapuia Chongthu, Monjul Baruah, Reema Borah, Himjyoti Talukdar, Suraj Duara, Himangshu Prasad Das, Deep Choudhury, Kangkan Deka have made an impact with their powerful and culturally-rooted narratives. Young filmmakers have moved beyond the stereotypical notion that insurgency is their chief thematic concern, focusing instead on regional stories and realities. Their films transcend the linguistic, cultural and geographic confines to strike a chord with audiences across borders.



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RIMA DAS

